One Day Retreat Talk Notes
10 October 2026

I wanted to start off today by sharing with you a koan from a collection called "The Book of Serenity". This has two characters, Dizang and Fayan from 9th/ 10th century China.

Just to set the scene, a spiritual seeker Fayan, a monk, was travelling around with other monks - he was unsettled in his own mind and practice - and possibly in search of a teacher. There was inclement weather - rain, snow, swollen rivers. They were forced to take shelter in Dizang's temple. They all chatted around the brazier.

> Dizang asked Fayan: So, where are you off to?
> Fayan replied: I am on pilgrimage
> Dizang asked: Why are you on pilgrimage?
> Fayan replied: I don't know
> Diyang said: Not knowing most intimate.
>
> — *"Not knowing is most intimate", Case 20, The Book of Serenity.*

1. Themes: Pilgrimage

- Exploring the physical world
- Meeting other people
- Seeing how they live
- Challenge ourselves
- A sense of freedom and discovery

We discover the world; the world discovers us; we see more and more of ourselves. Because in new experiences we always discover more about ourselves. We grow up a little. And, eventually, we long for home.

The practice of zen is like being on constant pilgrimage in the sense of living our lives in a way that is fresh and new and lived in a spirit of exploration. And open to the full range of human emotion. A vividly experienced life.

It does take time, it takes effort, commitment, to realise this. So we have to decide if we want to take this pilgrimage or not.

2. Themes: “I don’t know” - the practice of *not knowing*

You might have heard of the story of the spiritual seeker who went to visit a zen teacher; they were talking and they sat down to have tea. The teacher started pouring tea in the cup of the visitor and didn’t stop when it was full. The student asked what are you doing? The reply — This cup is like you, you already have all the answers so there is no room for anything new.

If we already know everything there’s not much conversation you can really have. We might think we know what other people should be doing. Especially our own children. We love to tell them what is what, no matter how old they get. My kids love that I know everything and have all the answers. I am usually right but anyway.

When we think we already know everything about a person, an experience, a situation, we are actually filtering through memories and associations in our own minds.

We often form opinions quickly about others, and see others through our own ways in which we frame the world. So we are not seeing the reality of how others are, for example.

We like security and so we expend a lot of effort to try to control, map things out, and create certainty. When really the only security we can really map out is learning out to be with life as it unfolds in its own mysterious way.

So the practice is about not pre-supposing too much. We are talking about leaning into a sense of adaptability in our thinking. So its a way of inhabiting life:

Be with it, move with it; when you lose your way, come back.
It is always there for you, awaiting your return.

3. Themes: Not knowing is most intimate.

This is such a beautiful expression. Closest, without boundary, no pretence. Intimacy is being (with) what you feel, (with) what others are saying and doing. Not pretending it is something else or putting frameworks between ourselves and experiencing; not adding on a bunch of pointless opinions and fears.

We can choose to live at a distance from our life or we can live immersed in it, open, curious, undefended; ready and willing to meet it, experience it, enjoy it, be surprised by it. The last talk I gave was “Welcome to the world of being surprised”.

The practice of zen is being:

simple, joyful, and open to possibility.

~~ To finish off ~~

From the poem, *It* —“Everyone alive is born gifted with true sight. How do you see these koans with your own eyes?”

It

One by one many leaves
the colours of autumn
let go of their twigs and fall

The cold cloud full of rain
passes above
the hollow of the mountain

Everyone alive
is born gifted
with true sight

How do you see
these koans
with your own eyes?

— *Muso Soseki*

Translation W. S. Merwin and Sōiku Shigematsu
in W.S. Merwin’s *East Window*